

Episode 131: Once Upon a Time... 75 – 1994 Part 9 – *Sailor Moon S*Movie Bank Cut Blues

Yes yes, it's summer vacation for elementary, middle, and high school students. Well, aside from exam students, I hope children who aren't can spend a summer playing around like little pigs and having various experiences. Oh, but no bad behaviour! (laugh)

By the way, I didn't know this, but recently even Tokyo elementary schools apparently have summer vacation only until around August 25th. Apparently because they made Saturdays holidays, there aren't enough class hours.

Hmm, how is that?

We don't have children so I can't speak carelessly, but where exactly were the benefits of making Saturday a holiday? Ah, but thanks to that, Saturday morning anime programmes are viable, right? If it weren't a holiday, nobody would watch anime on Saturday mornings. ...As one of the staff for Saturday morning broadcast *Ultra!! Mecha-Mote Chairman*, I'm asking myself such questions.

Anyway, summer vacation should really be a holiday until August 31st for proper closure. Don't you feel that way? Right?

Now then.

TV series theatrical adaptations inevitably involve bank cut modifications for theatrical compatibility. *Sailor Moon* always uses transformation bank cuts and special attack bank cuts from the TV series in theatrical versions too. This was actually quite troublesome.

TV then was still fully analogue broadcast, so aspect ratio was 3:4. Meanwhile theatrical works were basically Vista frame at 9:16. This difference was troublesome.

If we could set theatrical photography frames by trimming to match TV's 3:4 frame width, basic cel materials could use TV ones as-is. But this didn't work well. Width-matched trimming would often cut off cel tops and bottoms, so animation that fit full-size nicely in frame top-bottom would have character heads or feet cut off when top-bottom trimmed, sometimes even missing everything above the neck. This obviously couldn't be used. So basic frame modification mainly meant expanding horizontally to match top-bottom.

At that time, when there were reasons like completely redoing colours or modifying movement itself, we could say "can't help it!" and create new cels from scratch with large cels (Vista cels), but the most troublesome was when directors helpfully reset modification frames right to the margins of current TV cel blanks and gave instructions for additions and painting additions to current cels. Accordingly, cel modifications would paint as far as cel blanks allowed horizontally.

This was the worst kind of troublesome!

I wanted to say don't do unnecessary things! (laugh)

Since these were cels already used many times for photography, they had scratches and some deterioration. Adding new lines and painting there, and as I wrote before, even paints with the same colour numbers had slight colour and brightness differences depending on production periods. So careless painting additions could result in subtly different colours in added parts.

Well, honestly since it's frame edges, it didn't matter much in cuts moving energetically. But that modification work itself was troublesome and annoying (wry laugh). Checking cel modification completions was also annoying. Thinking it was probably fine and checking only lightly before sending to photography, assistant directors would say "Um, the painted cel and mask don't match..." for retakes (wry laugh). That's right. Bank cuts had incredibly complex photography masks, and naturally these all needed painting

additions for frame modifications too. Since it's additions to painted cels, naturally hand trace, which would shift. Good grief (wry laugh).

Moreover!

There were many bank cuts. Rather, increasing numbers. When new Sailor Warriors appeared, transformation banks and special attack banks increased by that headcount...

Since theatrical versions were definitely being made, when creating new bank cuts, couldn't they create animation + finishing from the start to handle large 9:16 frames! ...I resented TV staff for each incident.

In today's digitised era, painting data (cels) are digital, so such painting additions are relatively easier. Masks are also created accurately by computers through batch processing without mistakes or shifting. HD-compatible programmes definitely have the same 9:16 aspect ratio as theatrical versions, so frame modifications themselves often don't exist.

So current *PreCure* series are probably still easier (laugh). Well, they probably have their own difficulties now (wry laugh).

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